

APPLIQUÉ TECHNIQUES

Appliqué is a decorative technique in which shapes are cut from one fabric and applied to a background fabric. It has been used in quilting for centuries

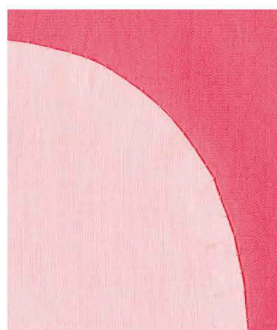
and is found on many other items, from clothing to cushions. Hand appliqué is the traditional method, but working by machine can be just as effective.

▶ STITCHES FOR APPLIQUÉ

Appliquéd shapes can be attached to the background in two ways, either hidden (using blind stitch) or calling attention to themselves as part of the design. Machine appliqué is almost always worked with decorative

stitches such as zigzag or satin stitch, or with one of the many stitches programmed into modern sewing machines.

BLIND STITCH OR SLIP STITCH



Bring the needle up on the right side of the background fabric, next to the turned-under edge of the shape being applied. Insert a few threads into the folded edge. Go back through the background fabric and continue taking tiny stitches 3mm ($\frac{1}{8}$ in) apart around the entire shape.

BLANKET STITCH



Bring the needle up on the right side of the background fabric, next to the turned-under edge of the shape being applied. Take a stitch into the shape 3–6mm ($\frac{1}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{4}$ in) to the right and perpendicular to the edge. Bring the needle out at the edge and loop the thread under the point. Pull tight and repeat.

TIPS FOR APPLIQUÉ

- Blanket stitch (above, right) is the most popular decorative stitch for hand appliqué, but many basic embroidery stitches can be used as decoration, including cross stitch, herringbone, chain stitch, and feather stitch.
- Make sure that decorative stitches sit tight against the turned-under edge and are in proportion with the size of the applied pieces.
- In most appliqué techniques, a seam allowance has to be added to the shapes. The secret is to make an allowance that is wide enough to keep fraying at bay and narrow enough to be undetectable once it has been stitched.
- Most seam allowances for appliqué can be cut by eye, following the outline of the shape. Remember that you can trim

away any excess as you work, but you can't add it once it has been removed. The ideal seam allowance is around 3mm ($\frac{1}{8}$ in).

- If you need only one piece of a particular shape, draw it on tracing paper and cut it out. Pin the tracing paper shape to the fabric and cut it out, in the same way as a dressmaking pattern.
- Appliqué designs usually have a right and a wrong side. When transferring a design, make sure that the right side of the fabric will be the right way around when the shape is cut out and applied.
- Some methods call for the outline of a design to be marked on the background fabric. In this case, make sure that the outline will be covered or can be removed

when the stitching is completed. Draw the design lightly on the right side of the fabric or tack around the outlines.

- When tacking, make sure that any knots are on the wrong side of the background fabric, as this will make it easier to remove the thread later.
- If the fabric is light or you have access to a lightbox, you may be able to trace from an original pattern directly onto the fabric.
- When working machine appliqué, work a practice row or two using the same fabrics as the design to make sure your settings are correct.